

PRODUCT REQUIREMENTS DOCUMENT

# RGV Innovation Ecosystem Cardinal Map

*A Community-Owned Digital Infrastructure for the Rio Grande Valley Innovation Ecosystem*

Rio Grande City → Weslaco → McAllen → Harlingen → Brownsville

|             |                                                       |
|-------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| Version     | 1.0 — V1 Specification                                |
| Prepared by | Frontera Leadership Institute (FLI)<br>/ LMNTS        |
| Date        | April 2026                                            |
| Framework   | Ideal Innovation Ecosystem (I2E)<br>— 10-Pillar Model |
| Status      | Draft — For Stakeholder Review                        |

# 1. Vision and Purpose

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**The RGV Innovation Ecosystem Cardinal Map** is an open-source, community-owned digital platform that makes the Rio Grande Valley's innovation ecosystem legible, navigable, and self-reinforcing for everyone inside it.

The RGV has all the ingredients of a thriving innovation ecosystem: strong educational institutions, a growing pool of talented builders, committed economic development organizations, emerging capital interest, and proximity to one of the most dynamic binational corridors in North America. What it lacks is a shared map — a common infrastructure that lets every player see every other player, understand where they fit, and navigate toward the connections that help them grow.

This platform is that map. It is not a pitch deck or a promotional tool. It is a cardinal infrastructure: the navigational reference that the whole ecosystem uses to understand itself.

## 1.1 What This Platform Does

- Maps all 10 pillars of the RGV innovation ecosystem using the I2E (Ideal Innovation Ecosystem) framework
- Shows every actor in the ecosystem — by pillar, by location, and by what they offer and need
- Guides each player type to the connections most relevant to their role and stage
- Visualizes gaps and underserved areas so EDOs, funders, and policy leaders can target their work
- Accepts community submissions and corrections, so the map stays current through collective stewardship
- Provides both a list view and a geographic map view, covering all four RGV counties

## 1.2 What This Platform Is Not

- It is not a job board, a funding marketplace, or a procurement portal — though it may connect people to those things
- It is not a gated or paywalled resource — in Version 1, all content is fully public
- It is not a static directory — it is a living document that the community maintains
- It is not controlled by any single organization — the community owns the data

## 1.3 Long-Term Vision

This platform becomes the default navigational reference for the RGV innovation ecosystem — the first place anyone opens when they want to understand who is doing what, where the gaps are, and how to connect. Over time it serves as the region's shared memory: recording not just who is here now, but how the ecosystem has grown, where investments paid off, and which gaps were filled.

## 2. Geographic Scope and Inclusion Criteria

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### 2.1 Primary Geographic Coverage

The platform covers the four counties of the Rio Grande Valley:

- Cameron County — Brownsville, Harlingen, San Benito, Los Fresnos
- Hidalgo County — McAllen, Edinburg, Mission, Pharr, Weslaco, Donna, Alamo
- Starr County — Rio Grande City, Roma
- Willacy County — Raymondville, Lyford

The geographic map view will display all of these counties with city-level pin placement for each actor. The platform should make visible the reality that Starr and Willacy counties are systematically underserved by the innovation ecosystem — those gaps are features, not oversights.

### 2.2 Outside-Region Inclusion Criteria

Actors based outside the RGV may be included if they meet at least one of the following criteria:

- Funders and investors: Must have made at least one documented investment in an RGV-based company, OR must have publicly participated in an RGV pitch event, demo day, or program (e.g., serving as a judge, mentor, or limited partner in an RGV-focused fund), OR must have formally submitted interest in investing in the RGV through an EDO, accelerator, or this platform.
- Service providers: Must have an active client relationship with at least one RGV-based startup or institution.
- Corporate partners: Must have an active procurement relationship, partnership, or pilot program with an RGV-based venture or institution.
- State and federal agencies: Included regardless of physical location if their programs directly serve RGV-based actors.

**Example:** Alamo Angels (San Antonio) is included because they have demonstrated investment interest and activity in the RGV. A San Antonio-based VC with no RGV activity is not included.

Outside-region actors are clearly labeled with their home location and their connection to the RGV, so users can distinguish between locally-rooted resources and regionally-accessible ones.

## **2.3 Binational Acknowledgment**

The RGV ecosystem does not end at the Rio Grande. The platform acknowledges the binational dimension — particularly the talent and business community in Matamoros and Reynosa — without attempting to fully map the Mexican side in Version 1. Binational actors (companies, individuals, or organizations with documented activity on both sides) may be listed with a “Binational” tag. A full binational expansion may be scoped for a future version.

### 3. Guiding Principles

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| Principle                          | What It Means in Practice                                                                                                                                                       |
|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Community First                    | The data belongs to the community, not to any single organization. Governance, editorial authority, and data licensing reflect this.                                            |
| Radical Transparency               | Gaps are visible. Underserved areas are named. Missing pillars are flagged. The map shows the ecosystem as it is, not as it aspires to be.                                      |
| Stage Awareness                    | A pre-seed founder and a growth-stage company need different things. The platform respects developmental stages and does not show everyone the same content.                    |
| Open Source by Default             | All code and data are open. Anyone can fork the database. The community can audit and extend the platform.                                                                      |
| Accountability Without Gatekeeping | Anyone can submit. Not everything gets published without review. Accountability is built into the system through named submissions and annual verification — not through walls. |
| Geographic Honesty                 | The map shows where the ecosystem is dense and where it is absent. Rio Grande City and Willacy County get the same visual weight as McAllen and Brownsville.                    |
| Usefulness Over Comprehensiveness  | A well-curated list of 80 verified actors is more useful than an unverified list of 500.                                                                                        |

## 4. Player Types and Jobs to Be Done

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The platform serves eight distinct player types. Each arrives with different goals, different needs, and different points of connection. The platform's navigation is organized around these types — not as rigid categories, but as entry points that shape what the user sees first.

### 4.1 Founders and Entrepreneurs

The most complex user type because their needs are deeply stage-dependent. A first-time founder with an idea and a growth-stage company preparing for a Series A should not see the same content.

| Stage          | Primary Jobs to Be Done                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Idea Stage     | Find a program or workshop to sharpen the concept. Find a peer community to stress-test the idea. Access free resources (SBDC, university programs). No capital exposure yet.                                    |
| Pre-Seed       | Find incubators and accelerators accepting applications. Access non-dilutive capital (grants, competitions, SBDC). Find legal and financial guidance at low or no cost. Find a co-founder or early collaborator. |
| Seed           | Access angel capital and accelerator investment. Find professional service providers (legal, accounting). Recruit early talent from UTRGV, STC, and TSTC. Validate with a first customer or pilot.               |
| Growth / Scale | Land institutional customers (SpaceX, DHR, school districts, city contracts). Access later-stage capital. Engage EDOs and policy advocates for procurement and incentive programs. Hire at scale.                |

### 4.2 Investors and Funders

Funders in the RGV operate across a wide spectrum — from federal grant programs and community development financial institutions (CDFIs) to angel networks and venture-adjacent organizations. The platform serves them equally but gives each a distinct entry point.

- Find other funders to coordinate with, avoid duplication, and build co-investment relationships
- Identify deal flow — which programs have active cohorts that produce capital-ready founders
- Understand where capital is absent — which geographies and stages are underserved
- Find EDO programs that can stack with private capital to de-risk investment

- Signal their own RGV investment activity so founders can find them

**Key insight:** In the RGV, the capital problem is partly a coordination problem. Funders don't know who else is active, so they either pile onto the same deal flow or miss each other entirely. The platform surfaces funders to each other, not just to founders.

### 4.3 Academic Institutions

Universities, community colleges, technical colleges, and K-12 institutions all need to connect outward from their campuses into the startup and innovation ecosystem. Their needs fall into four areas:

- Find employers — startups, corporates, and EDOs that need interns, entry-level hires, and contract workers
- Find accelerator and EDO partners to build structured talent pipelines — not one-off internships, but repeating placements with named partners
- Find corporate partners for capstone projects, applied research, and curriculum co-design
- Coordinate with other institutions to avoid duplicating programs and to identify true gaps in the educational landscape

**Key insight:** Institutions need structured pipelines, not referrals. The platform should surface which organizations are actively seeking student talent and in what capacity — not just “who hires” but “who has a repeatable, structured pathway.”

### 4.4 Economic Development Organizations (EDOs)

EDOs are the most “meta” users — they are not just navigating the ecosystem, they are stewarding it. They use the platform at two levels: operational (find startups to recruit) and strategic (understand ecosystem health).

- Find startups to recruit into active programs
- Coordinate with other EDOs to avoid program duplication and create complementary offerings
- Find academic institutions to build talent pipeline programs with
- See the diagnostic view — which pillars are weak, which geographies are underserved, what should be built next
- Communicate their programs and availability to founders, institutions, and funders



## **4.5 Corporate and Innovation Buyers**

Companies that want to source local innovation, hire local talent, or become anchor customers for RGV startups.

- Find startups that solve a specific problem they have (local procurement and pilot opportunities)
- Find talent pipelines from institutions aligned with their hiring needs
- Find EDOs offering incentive programs for corporate partnerships
- Connect with accelerators to sponsor cohorts or serve as mentors

## **4.6 Service Providers**

Legal, accounting, HR, consulting, marketing, and technical service providers who serve the startup ecosystem.

- Get discovered — be findable when a founder or EDO searches for a specific type of service
- Get embedded in accelerator and EDO programs as a trusted partner
- Find right-stage founders — not so early they cannot pay, not so established they have their own providers
- Refer work to other providers outside their scope, and receive appropriate referrals in return

## **4.7 Students and Emerging Builders**

Students across K-12, community college, university, and technical programs who want to enter the startup ecosystem.

- Find programs they can join right now — not ‘apply in six months’ but open enrollment today
- Find internship and project opportunities with startups and innovation programs
- Find peers building at a similar level
- Understand the path from where they are to where they want to be

## **4.8 Government and Policy Leaders**

City council members, county officials, state agency staff, and federal representatives who want to understand and support the ecosystem.

- See the full ecosystem at a glance for planning, reporting, and public communication

- Identify gaps to target with policy, funding, or enabling legislation
- Connect startups and EDOs to federal and state resource programs
- Demonstrate the impact of public investment through ecosystem data over time

## 5. User Journey Maps

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The following journeys describe how each player type enters the platform, navigates to their primary goal, and makes a connection. Each journey is designed to work in under three minutes from landing page to meaningful discovery.

### 5.1 Founder Journey — Stage-Gated Navigation

Entry: Homepage → Select “Founder / Entrepreneur” → Select stage → Filtered map

#### Step 1 — First Base: Educate and Connect (Idea and Pre-Seed)

- Platform shows: Education & Pipeline programs (Pillar 4) + Community & Peer Groups (Pillar 6)
- Featured: FLI, eBridge, UTRGV Innovation Hub, STC Entrepreneurship Center, 1909, RGV SBDC
- User action: Click through to a program profile → see application link, location, stage requirements, contact

#### Step 2 — Second Base: Build and Get Support (Pre-Seed and Seed)

- Platform shows: Incubators & Accelerators (Pillar 7) + Professional Services (Pillar 5)
- Stage filter auto-applied: only shows programs accepting founders at the user’s selected stage
- Gap notice shown if no programs are accepting applications in a given county

#### Step 3 — Third Base: Capital and Talent (Seed and Growth)

- Platform shows: Capital Providers (Pillar 3) + Talent Pool (Pillar 2)
- Capital filter separates: grant/non-dilutive vs. angel vs. institutional
- Talent section links to UTRGV, STC, and TSTC hiring pages

#### Step 4 — Home Plate: Customers and Policy (Growth and Scale)

- Platform shows: Innovation Customers (Pillar 1) + Advocacy & Policy (Pillar 8)
- User can filter by industry (healthcare, government, education, technology, logistics)
- Policy contacts show BEDC, MEDC, county contacts, and congressional offices

### 5.2 Investor / Funder Journey

Entry: Homepage → Select “Investor / Funder” → Select intent → Filtered view

### **Intent A: Find co-investors and build my circle**

- Platform shows: All actors in Capital Providers pillar (Pillar 3)
- Filter by: type (angel, institutional, grant, debt, CDFI), stage served, geography
- Each funder profile shows: org type, stage focus, sectors, RGV activity (investments made or interest stated), contact method
- Outside-region funders clearly labeled with their connection to the RGV

### **Intent B: Find deal flow**

- Platform shows: Active cohorts at FLI, eBridge, UTRGV, STC
- Links to Demo Days, pitch events, and graduation dates
- In V2: founders who opt in to investor discovery appear here

### **Intent C: Understand where capital is absent**

- Ecosystem Health view (see Section 7.8) shows capital deserts by geography and stage
- Starr County and Willacy County surface as capital-underserved areas
- User can filter the map to show “capital density” — how many funders serve each county

## **5.3 Academic Institution Journey**

Entry: Homepage → Select “Educator / University” → Select intent → Filtered view

### **Intent A: Place students into internships and jobs**

- Platform shows: Innovation Customers (Pillar 1) + Incubators (Pillar 7) filtered for “hiring or accepting interns”
- User can see which organizations have posted structured pipeline programs vs. ad hoc hiring

### **Intent B: Find pipeline partners**

- Platform shows: Accelerators and EDOs with workforce development components
- FLI’s Pipeline-to-Program pathway visible as a model
- User can submit a “looking for pipeline partner” posting in V2

### **Intent C: Avoid duplication with other institutions**

- Platform shows full Education & Pipelines pillar (Pillar 4) with program details

- Users can see what programs exist in which counties — and where no programs exist

## 5.4 EDO Journey

Entry: Homepage → Select “EDO / Ecosystem Builder” → Land on Ecosystem Health view + full map

- Default view shows the Ecosystem Health Dashboard (pillar strength, geographic distribution, gap map)
- From Health Dashboard, EDO can drill into any weak pillar or underserved county
- Operational view: filter for startups in pre-seed or seed stage looking for programs (V2 with founder accounts)
- Coordination view: see all other EDOs, their current programs, and their focus areas to avoid duplication
- Submission access: EDO can flag a known gap directly from the map interface

## 5.5 Corporate / Innovation Buyer Journey

Entry: Homepage → Select “Corporate / Innovation Buyer” → See two entry points: “Find a solution” or “Find talent”

### Find a solution:

- Browse Incubators & Accelerators (Pillar 7) to find current cohort companies
- In V2: search startup profiles by industry and problem area

### Find talent:

- Browse Education & Pipelines (Pillar 4) with filter for institution type and program focus
- See structured hiring relationships already established between institutions and employers

## 5.6 Student / Emerging Builder Journey

Entry: Homepage → Select “Student / Builder” → See “Programs open now” as first content

- Default view emphasizes open-enrollment programs, not future applications

- Peer community listings: Valley Young Professionals, FLI Ambassador Program, 1909 community events
- Internship pathway: links to institutions and companies with structured student engagement
- Path visualizer: a simplified version of the four-base journey showing the typical student-to-founder route

## 5.7 Government / Policy Leader Journey

Entry: Homepage → Select “Government / Policy” → Land on Ecosystem Health Dashboard

- Full diagnostic view: pillar strength indicators, geographic distribution, known gaps
- Resource mapping: which federal and state programs are currently active in the RGV
- Policy leverage points: which pillars most need enabling conditions vs. direct funding
- Export view: ability to download a summary report of ecosystem status (useful for legislative briefings)

## 6. The 10-Pillar Framework (I2E)

The platform is organized around the Ideal Innovation Ecosystem (I2E) framework, which defines ten structural components required for an ecosystem to reliably convert innovation into outcomes. Each actor in the platform is mapped to one or more pillars. Each pillar has a diagnostic strength indicator in the ecosystem health view.

| #  | Pillar                      | Capacity                | RGV Status (2026)                       | Primary RGV Actors                                                          |
|----|-----------------------------|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1  | Innovation Customers        | Demand & Adoption       | Active — anchor presence                | SpaceX, DHR Health, City govts, School districts                            |
| 2  | Talent Pool                 | Build & Execute         | Active — formalization gap              | UTRGV, STC, TSTC graduates; FLI alumni; binational engineers                |
| 3  | Capital Providers           | Risk Capital            | Partial — critical gap in angel/venture | EDA, USDA, SBA, IBC Bank, Generations FCU, Alamo Angels                     |
| 4  | Education & Pipelines       | Talent Development      | Strong                                  | UTRGV, STC, TSTC, IDEA, FLI, BISD/HISD CTE                                  |
| 5  | Professional Services       | Friction Removal        | Thin — limited startup-savvy PSPs       | SBDC, regional CPAs, IP/corporate law firms, TX RioGrande Legal Aid         |
| 6  | Communities & Peer Groups   | Trust & Reputation      | Active                                  | Chambers, 1909, Valley Young Professionals, FLI Ambassador Program          |
| 7  | Incubators & Accelerators   | Company Formation       | Active                                  | eBridge/BCIC, FLI, UTRGV Innovation Hub, STC, 1909, SBDC                    |
| 8  | Advocacy & Policy           | Permission & Unblocking | Active                                  | BEDC, MEDC, RGVEDA, Cameron/Hidalgo County, TX EcDev, Congressional offices |
| 9  | Shared Operating Platform   | Memory & Coordination   | Critical gap                            | This platform (proposed); LinkedIn groups (informal only)                   |
| 10 | Governance & Accountability | Standards & Outcomes    | Fragmented                              | BEDC/MEDC, RGVEDA, City                                                     |

|  |  |  |  |                                   |
|--|--|--|--|-----------------------------------|
|  |  |  |  | Councils,<br>Commissioners Courts |
|--|--|--|--|-----------------------------------|

*Note:* The I2E framework also defines two external support structures: the Council on Innovation (COI) — an advisory and diagnostic layer external to the system — and the Funded House (FH), a capital interface module. Both may be represented on the platform in future versions as designated support roles rather than ecosystem actors.



## 7. Information Architecture

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### 7.1 Site Structure

| Page               | Purpose                                         | Key Features                                                           |
|--------------------|-------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Homepage           | Entry point: role selection + ecosystem preview | Role cards, intent selection, CTA to map, ecosystem health teaser      |
| The Map            | Full ecosystem, all actors, all pillars         | List view + geographic view, all filters, gap indicators               |
| Pillar Pages (x10) | One page per I2E pillar                         | Pillar description, all actors, gaps, connections to adjacent pillars  |
| Actor Profiles     | Individual org/program pages                    | Profile fields, pillar tags, location, what they offer, how to connect |
| My Journey         | Role-based path (bookmarkable)                  | Four-base progression, stage filter, direct links to relevant actors   |
| Ecosystem Health   | Diagnostic overview for EDOs and policy         | Pillar strength, geographic distribution, gap registry, trend data     |
| Submit / Correct   | Community contribution form                     | New listing submission, correction form, review queue confirmation     |
| About / Governance | Platform context and ownership model            | Who built this, how it's governed, data license, community ownership   |

### 7.2 Homepage Design Logic

The homepage must answer one question in under five seconds: “Where do I go if I’m a [X] trying to [Y]?”

Structure:

1. Hero section: Platform name, one-line description, and a “Who are you?” role selector with 8 role cards
2. Role selection leads immediately to an intent selector (“What are you trying to do?”) — 2-3 options per role

3. After role + intent, user lands on a filtered map view with the most relevant pillar(s) highlighted
4. Secondary CTA beneath the hero: “Show me the full map” — for users who want to browse without filtering
5. Below the fold: Ecosystem health snapshot (3 metrics: active actors, known gaps, last updated)

## 7.3 The Map — Dual View

**List View:** Filterable cards for every actor in the ecosystem.

- Each card shows: org name, pillar badge(s), player type, city/county, brief descriptor, status (active / emerging / gap)
- Filter bar: Pillar (multi-select), Player Type, County, Stage Served, Status
- Sort options: Alphabetical, Recently Added, County, Pillar
- Gap entries appear as dashed-border cards labeled “Gap — No Actor Found” with a “Suggest an Organization” button

**Geographic View:** Interactive map of the four RGV counties.

- Technology: Leaflet.js + OpenStreetMap (open-source, no cost, community-aligned)
- Pins placed at city level (not street address) for privacy and simplicity
- Pin color encodes pillar (10 colors, with a legend)
- Clicking a pin opens an actor profile card overlay
- Filter bar mirrors the list view filters — same data, different rendering
- County boundaries drawn and labeled
- “Show Gaps” toggle: overlays a heat map showing which counties have few or no actors in a selected pillar
- Zoom level determines cluster behavior: at regional zoom, pins cluster; at city zoom, individual pins show

## 7.4 Actor Profiles

Each actor in the ecosystem has a profile page (or card in the map view). Profiles are the atomic unit of the platform.

Required fields:

- Organization name
- Player type (Funder, EDO, Incubator, University, etc.)
- Pillar(s) served (1-10, can be multiple)
- City and county (RGV) or home base + RGV connection type (for outside-region actors)
- Brief description (250 words maximum)

- What they offer (tagged: programs, capital, services, employment, mentorship, etc.)
- Who they serve (tagged player types)
- Status: Active / Emerging / Inactive / Gap
- How to connect: website URL, application link, or contact email

Optional fields:

- Stage served (for programs and capital providers)
- Industry focus (for corporate buyers and funders)
- Sectors of interest
- Upcoming events or open cohorts
- Related actors (linked profiles)

## 7.5 Ecosystem Health Dashboard

Accessible to all users in V1 from the EDO / Policy entry point or from a dedicated “Ecosystem Health” link in the navigation.

- Pillar Strength Bar: Each of the 10 pillars shown with a strength indicator (Strong / Active / Thin / Gap) based on actor count and verified activity
- Geographic Coverage Map: Heat map showing actor density by county, filterable by pillar
- Gap Registry: Named list of known gaps with pillar, geography, and a “Submit an actor for this gap” button
- Data Freshness Indicator: Shows when each pillar was last reviewed and what percentage of listings have been verified in the past 12 months
- Trend line (V2): Actor count over time per pillar, showing ecosystem growth

## 8. Feature Specifications

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### 8.1 Role + Intent Onboarding

**Behavior:** Two-step entry that personalizes the user’s view without requiring an account.

- Step 1: User selects their role from 8 cards on the homepage
- Step 2: User selects their primary intent from 2-3 options specific to their role
- The platform immediately navigates to a filtered map view based on role + intent
- A persistent “you are viewing as [role]” banner allows role change without starting over
- Role selection is not required to access the full map — it is an accelerant, not a gate

### 8.2 Filters

All filters work across both list view and geographic map view simultaneously.

| Filter       | Options                                                                                | Notes                                                               |
|--------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Pillar       | 1–10 (multi-select)                                                                    | Selecting multiple pillars shows all actors in any of those pillars |
| Player Type  | Funder, EDO, University, Incubator, Corporate, Service Provider, Community, Government | Maps to org categories on profiles                                  |
| County       | Cameron, Hidalgo, Starr, Willacy, Outside-RGV                                          | Outside-RGV shows actors with documented RGV activity               |
| Stage Served | Idea, Pre-Seed, Seed, Growth, All Stages                                               | Only appears when Pillar 3 or 7 is selected                         |
| Status       | Active, Emerging, Gap                                                                  | Gap entries show even when empty — they are data too                |
| Service Type | Programs, Capital, Mentorship, Employment, Legal, Accounting, Policy                   | Free-text tags from actor profiles                                  |

### 8.3 Geographic Map View — Technical Spec

- Map library: Leaflet.js (open-source, no licensing costs)

- Base tiles: OpenStreetMap (open-source, community-aligned)
- County boundary data: U.S. Census TIGER/Line shapefiles (public domain)
- Pin coordinates: city-center level (not street address)
- Pin clustering: enabled at zoom level < 10; individual pins show at zoom >= 10
- Pin color: 10 colors mapped to 10 pillars, accessible palette with legend
- Hover state: org name and player type tooltip
- Click state: actor profile card overlay (same fields as list view card)
- Gap overlay: semi-transparent county fill showing “actor density” for the selected pillar filter
- Mobile responsive: map collapses to list view as default on screens below 640px wide

## 8.4 Community Submission and Correction Flow

The platform is built on the assumption that the community knows things the administrators do not. Submissions are welcomed, reviewed, and published with credit.

**New Listing Submission:** Anyone can submit an organization for inclusion.

- Form fields: Org name, org type, pillar(s), city, brief description, what they offer, who they serve, website/contact, submitter name and email (not published)
- Submitter email is used only for: (a) submission status updates, (b) follow-up questions from reviewers, and (c) annual verification pings in V2
- Submission goes to a moderation queue
- Reviewer approves, requests more info, or declines with a reason
- Approved listings appear with a “Community Added” badge for 90 days
- Submitter receives an email notification when their submission is published

**Correction / Update:** Anyone can flag an error or suggest an update.

- Every actor profile has a visible “Suggest a correction” link
- Form fields: what is wrong / what should it say / submitter name and email
- Corrections go to the same moderation queue
- If correction is accepted, the profile is updated and the submitter is notified

**Gap Flagging:** Users can formally flag a missing actor type in a given area.

- From any pillar page or map view, a “Flag a gap” option is available
- Form: what type of actor is missing, in what county, why it matters
- Approved gap flags appear in the Gap Registry on the Ecosystem Health Dashboard

## 8.5 Search

- Free-text search bar available from all pages
- Searches: org name, description, tags, and pillar
- Returns ranked results (exact name match first, then tag/description match)
- No results state includes a prominent “Suggest an organization” CTA

## 9. Data Model

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### 9.1 Actor Profile Schema

| Field           | Type          | Required?      | Notes                                                                                                     |
|-----------------|---------------|----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| id              | UUID          | Yes            | Auto-generated                                                                                            |
| name            | String        | Yes            | Organization name                                                                                         |
| org_type        | Enum          | Yes            | Funder, EDO, University, Incubator, Accelerator, Community, Corporate, Service Provider, Government, K-12 |
| pillars         | Array[Int]    | Yes            | One or more pillar IDs (1–10)                                                                             |
| city            | String        | Yes            | Primary city of operation                                                                                 |
| county          | Enum          | Yes            | Cameron, Hidalgo, Starr, Willacy, Outside-RGV                                                             |
| rgv_connection  | String        | If outside-RGV | How this outside-region actor is active in the RGV (investment made, program partner, etc.)               |
| description     | Text          | Yes            | 250 words max                                                                                             |
| what_they_offer | Array[String] | Yes            | Tags: programs, capital, mentorship, employment, legal, etc.                                              |
| who_they_serve  | Array[Enum]   | Yes            | Player type tags                                                                                          |
| stages_served   | Array[Enum]   | Conditional    | Required if org_type is Funder, Incubator, or Accelerator. Options: Idea, Pre-Seed, Seed, Growth, All     |
| website_url     | URL           | No             | Main website                                                                                              |
| apply_url       | URL           | No             | Application or intake link if different from main site                                                    |
| contact_email   | Email         | No             | Public contact (shown on profile); distinct from submitter email                                          |
| status          | Enum          | Yes            | Active, Emerging, Inactive, Gap                                                                           |
| coordinates     | LatLng        | Auto           | Geocoded from city field for map view                                                                     |
| date_added      | Date          | Auto           | When published to platform                                                                                |
| last_verified   | Date          | Auto           | Date of most recent manual verification                                                                   |
| verified_by     | String        | Auto           | Internal: who verified (admin or account owner in V2)                                                     |

|                     |         |                        |                                                                |
|---------------------|---------|------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| community_submitted | Boolean | Auto                   | True if submitted by community (not admin)                     |
| submitter_email     | Email   | If community-submitted | Not published. Used for verification pings and follow-up only. |

## 9.2 Gap Record Schema

When a pillar has no active actor in a given county, the platform generates or accepts a “Gap Record” that appears on the map and in the gap registry.

| Field        | Type   | Required? | Notes                                                                                   |
|--------------|--------|-----------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| pillar       | Int    | Yes       | Which of the 10 pillars is missing                                                      |
| county       | Enum   | Yes       | Where the gap exists                                                                    |
| description  | Text   | No        | What type of actor is needed and why it matters                                         |
| flagged_by   | String | No        | Community submitter name (optional) or “System”                                         |
| date_flagged | Date   | Auto      |                                                                                         |
| status       | Enum   | Auto      | Open, In Progress (a submission is under review), Filled (an actor now covers this gap) |



## 10. Submission and Review Workflow

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### 10.1 New Listing Submission Flow

6. User clicks “Submit an Organization” from any page (persistent link in navigation)
7. Form presented: all required fields from actor profile schema plus submitter name and email
8. User submits — receives confirmation email: “Thank you. Your submission is under review and will be published within 5 business days if approved.”
9. Submission appears in the administrator’s moderation queue
10. Reviewer has three options: (a) Approve as-is, (b) Request more info (email sent to submitter), (c) Decline with a reason (email sent to submitter)
11. If approved: listing goes live with “Community Added” badge for 90 days. Submitter receives notification.
12. If declined: submitter receives a clear explanation and, where appropriate, a suggestion for an alternative action (e.g., “This org does not currently meet our RGV activity criterion, but if they participate in a future program, please resubmit.”)

### 10.2 Correction Flow

13. User clicks “Suggest a correction” on any actor profile
14. Form: what is incorrect, what the correct information is, submitter name and email
15. Correction appears in moderation queue alongside the existing profile
16. Reviewer compares and either applies the correction, applies a modified version, or declines
17. Submitter notified in all cases

### 10.3 Review Standards

The following criteria guide approval decisions:

- The organization exists and is verifiable via a public web presence
- The organization genuinely operates in or for the RGV ecosystem (see Section 2.2 for outside-region criteria)
- The profile is accurate and not promotional in tone
- The submission does not duplicate an existing listing without meaningful distinction

## 10.4 Administrator Tools (V1)

- Simple moderation dashboard: pending queue, approved, declined
- Ability to edit any field before approving
- Ability to bulk-update verification dates
- Ability to manually mark a listing as “Needs Review” (e.g., if a key contact leaves the org)
- Export: CSV export of all listings for offline analysis

# 11. Version Roadmap

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## 11.1 Version 1 — Open and Public

V1 is designed to be launched quickly with maximum accessibility. No accounts required. Everything is public.

| Feature          | V1 Specification                                                                                 |
|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Access model     | Fully public. No account, login, or signup required to browse, search, or filter.                |
| Submissions      | Open. Submitter provides name and email (not published). Goes to human review before publishing. |
| Map views        | List view + geographic map (Leaflet.js + OpenStreetMap). Both views, all filters.                |
| Role navigation  | Role + intent selector on homepage. Filtered views for all 8 player types.                       |
| Actor profiles   | Static profiles managed by admin team. Updated via correction submissions.                       |
| Ecosystem health | Static diagnostic view, manually updated by admin team quarterly.                                |
| Verification     | Admin team verifies listings by hand on a rolling basis.                                         |

## 11.2 Version 2 — Member Accounts and Community Ownership

V2 adds an account layer for accountability and quality control without removing the open, public nature of the platform. The platform remains fully browsable without an account. Accounts are for organizations that want to own and maintain their own listings.

| Feature             | V2 Specification                                                                                                                                                                      |
|---------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Account creation    | Any organization may create an account to claim or create their listing. Email verification required. No cost.                                                                        |
| Listing ownership   | Account holders can update their own listing at any time without moderation (within schema constraints).                                                                              |
| Annual verification | Every account receives an annual email: “Is your information still current? Are you still the right contact for this listing?” Non-response after 30 days flags the listing as ‘Needs |

|                         |                                                                                                                                                |
|-------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                         | Verification.’ Non-response after 2 annual cycles archives the listing.                                                                        |
| Contact changes         | If a person leaves an org, account can be transferred to a new contact. Preserves listing history.                                             |
| Founder discoverability | Founders can opt in to being discoverable by funders and EDOs (separate from organization profiles).                                           |
| Opportunity posts       | Account holders can post open cohorts, job openings, or RFPs that appear in the map and relevant filtered views.                               |
| Open source data        | All listing data remains publicly downloadable in structured format (CSV or JSON). Accounts add a management layer; they do not lock the data. |

Open Source Commitment: The codebase is published under an open-source license (MIT or CC-BY-SA for data). The community can fork, audit, and extend the platform. No single organization owns the data. The platform operator (FLI / LMNTS in V1) holds editorial and governance authority until a community advisory board is established in V2.

## 12. Governance Model

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### 12.1 V1 Governance — Founding Operator Model

In Version 1, the Frontera Leadership Institute (FLI) and LMNTS serve as the founding operator — responsible for initial data curation, moderation, and editorial decisions. This is a trust-based custodial role, not ownership.

- FLI / LMNTS manages the moderation queue and review process
- All decisions are documented and auditable
- Any actor listed on the platform may request their listing be removed at any time
- The founding operator does not grant preference to affiliated organizations in listings or featured placement

### 12.2 V2 Governance — Community Advisory Board

In Version 2, a Community Advisory Board (CAB) is established to provide oversight and input on governance decisions. The CAB is drawn from the I2E's Council on Innovation (COI) model — external, advisory, non-binding on day-to-day operations but authoritative on governance changes.

- CAB members represent multiple player types: at minimum one funder, one EDO, one academic institution, one founder/entrepreneur, and one policy/government representative
- CAB meets quarterly to review platform health, submission quality, and governance policy
- CAB has authority to recommend governance changes, but operational decisions remain with the platform operator
- CAB members serve 2-year terms, staggered

### 12.3 Data License

All listing data is published under a Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 (CC BY-SA 4.0) license. This means:

- Anyone may use, copy, redistribute, or build upon the data
- Any derivative work must credit the RGV Innovation Ecosystem Map and use the same license
- Commercial use of the data is permitted under these conditions
- The license does not apply to submitter emails or other non-public personal information, which are held in confidence

## **12.4 Conflict of Interest Policy**

The founding operator and any future CAB member must recuse themselves from moderation decisions involving organizations to which they have a financial, employment, or significant personal relationship.

## 13. Open Questions for Stakeholder Input

The following questions require stakeholder input before development begins. They are not blocking — V1 can proceed with working assumptions — but they will shape decisions made during build.

| Question                                                                                     | Working Assumption (V1)                                                            | Stakeholder Input Needed From |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------|
| Who is the ongoing moderating organization after launch?                                     | FLI / LMNTS until CAB is established                                               | FLI board, EDO partners       |
| What is the funder inclusion review process? Who vets RGV activity claims?                   | Admin team verifies via public records and direct contact                          | Capital providers, BEDC/MEDC  |
| Should the platform include individual people (founders, angels) or only organizations?      | V1: organizations only. V2: opt-in individual profiles.                            | Founders, angel investors     |
| Should the platform be bilingual (English / Spanish) from launch?                            | English V1, bilingual V2                                                           | Community, BCIC, FLI          |
| What is the hosting model and cost structure?                                                | Low-cost static hosting (Netlify or Vercel) + open database (Supabase or Airtable) | FLI / LMNTS technical lead    |
| How is the gap registry validated? Who decides a gap is 'real'?                              | Any flagged gap with 3+ separate submissions is auto-elevated to the gap registry  | EDOs, CAB                     |
| Should listings include a 'last active' date sourced from public activity (website, social)? | Not in V1 — too complex to automate. Manual verification only.                     | Technical lead                |

**Next Steps:** Once stakeholder input on open questions is gathered, the recommended sequence is: (1) Finalize data schema and seed dataset with 50–80 verified RGV actors, (2) Build V1 as a static site with Airtable or Supabase backend, (3) Soft launch with EDO and academic partners for feedback, (4) Public launch with submission flow open, (5) Quarterly review cycle begins.